Parshas Bereishis: Knowing Our Worth, Embracing Our Words

Ascent from the Chagim

As we open Parshas Bereishis, we aren't simply reading about the beginning of the world, we are experiencing a renewal of reality itself. But we do so as people who have just emerged from the intense spiritual journey of Tishrei. We've crowned Hashem as King on Rosh Hashanah, purified ourselves on Yom Kippur, and basked in closeness and joy through Sukkos and Simchas Torah.

So what now? How do we carry that spiritual energy forward into the year?

The answer lies not only in the newness of the world, but in the role we play in that renewed world.

From Surrender to Strength

In Sefer Devarim, we saw the continuing theme of *bitul*, of nullification of my animalistic will before the will of Hashem, and of an individual learning how they are needed and able to contribute to the whole and the greater good.

But before we can surrender to the will of Hashem, we must first believe in the value of the self. Otherwise, what is it that we are surrendering? As we restart the Torah with Parshas Bereishis, a shift occurs. We are reintroduced to ourselves not as just parts of a whole, but as active partners in creation, each and every one of us having this focus and ability.

Hashem says, "נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם בְּצַלְמֵנוּ׃" — "Let us make man in Our image" (Bereishis 1:26). Rashi, quoting the Midrash (Bereishis Rabbah 8:7), explains that Hashem consulted His heavenly court. The act of creation was not unilateral. It was collaborative on one level, but not in essence — because when the Torah describes the actual creation of Adam, it says:

"וַיִּבְרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הָאָדָם בְּצַלְמוֹ" — "And G-d created man in His image" (Bereishis 1:27).

Not in their image. Not in the image of the angels. In Hashem's image.

And that's the key: we are not *mishutafim* because we were created by consensus, we are *mishutafim* because we were created in His image. And His *ratzon*, as proven by our very existence, is to create.

That *tzelem Elokim* is what empowers us to create, to choose, to speak, to shape, and to elevate. It's not an invitation to arrogance, but a call to responsibility.

The Koach of Speech

The most striking way that man reflects the Divine is in the power of speech. Hashem creates the world through speech. "וַיֹּאמֶר א-לֹהִים יְהִי אוֹר" — "And G-d said: Let there be light" (Bereishis 1:3).

Adam too is granted the power of words. He names each creature in Gan Eden, not arbitrarily, but with insight. The name he gives reflects the inner reality of that being.

But that power can be distorted. When Chava is persuaded by the *nachash* (snake) to eat from the Eitz HaDaas, she alters Hashem's words ever so slightly. And Adam, instead of taking responsibility, uses his words to shift blame: "The woman whom You gave me, she gave me from the tree." Chava then deflects as well: "The serpent deceived me."

From the beginning, we see the immense weight that words carry. They can name and words can create. But they can also mislead and avoid. The power of creation is in our mouths, but it comes with responsibility.

Had Adam used his power of speech to do Viduy, confession, when Hashem asked him where he was and what he had done, perhaps Hashem would have accepted this teshuva and would have never sent Adam and Chava out of eden to begin with as we are taught that teshuva existed before the world was created.

Created for Me, but Not First

The Gemara in Sanhedrin (37a) teaches that each person must say: *"בשבילי נברא העולם"* — "The world was created for me."

The human being was created last, not because he is least important, but because he is the purpose of creation.

Yet the very next page (Sanhedrin 38a) offers a critical counterbalance. The Rabbanim in the Gemara teach:

שֶׁאִם תִּזּוֹחַ דַּעְתּוֹ עָלָיו — אוֹמְרִים לוֹ: יַתּוּשׁ קִדְּמָךְ בְּמַעֲשֶׂה בְּרֵאשִׁית — "If he becomes haughty, he is told: The mosquito preceded you in creation."

We are at once the center of the banquet and the last guest to arrive. The universe was prepared for us, but we must enter with humility.

This duality is not a contradiction — it is the posture of a Jew. To carry greatness without arrogance. To bear responsibility without self-importance.

The Moon and Its Message

This balance finds profound expression in the story of the moon.

Rashi (Bereishis 1:16) brings the Midrash (Chullin 60b, Bereishis Rabbah 6:3): at first, the sun and moon were equal. But the moon protested: "Two kings cannot wear one crown." Hashem responded: "Go and diminish yourself."

The moon was made smaller, its light reflective rather than original.

But Hashem consoled the moon. The Jewish people would be linked to it. They would count their months by its phases. Righteous people would be compared to it.

The moon's power is not in its brightness, but in its timing, its cycles, and its constancy. It pulls the tides, influences the core of the earth, and governs the rhythm of time itself. And yet, it does so humbly, in the background, through borrowed light.

The Jewish people are like the moon. Sometimes full, sometimes diminished. Sometimes celebrated, sometimes forgotten. But we are always necessary. Our presence, even when unseen, sustains the world.

Our Power of Being Creators Through Speech

On Rosh Hashanah, we say *"יְהִי רָצוֹן"* — "May it be Your will…" We ask for health, for victory, for blessing — not through might or wealth, but through words.

And it is not only with Hashem that our words matter. It is with one another.

A soldier I know told me a story. Over a year ago, he met the father of one of the hostages who has now, baruch Hashem, been released. At the time, the situation seemed hopeless. But this young soldier, just a regular Jew, looked the father in the eye and blessed him, "You will see your son again. Hashem will help you."

He didn't know why he said it. He didn't even fully believe it himself. But he said it out of love, out of care, out of hope. And this week, he saw that father reunited with his son, holding a lulav, embracing in joy.

That is an example of the *koach of dibur*, the creating power of a Jew's words. When used properly, we have the ability to comfort, to bless and to impact the world and to even change creation itself.

There was no logical reason to believe that that father would ever be reunited with his son. But through loving compassion, that chayal's words may have been what was needed to power and to create a newer reality which allowed for that amazing and miraculous reunion.

A Final Charge

The world today feels uncertain. We have experienced loss, fear, and confusion. But the Torah tells us: you matter. **You** were created for a reason. **Your** words, **your** presence, **your** actions all have the power of creation from Hashem and they can change things.

So as we started with in the beginning, and to remind ourselves again: before we can fully surrender to the will of Hashem, we must first believe in the value of the self, my ability to grant comfort, to change the world, to heal others, and to create.

Parshas Bereishis is a time of renewal. A time to take on new commitments. To set goals. To speak words of love and blessing. To build, not destroy. To reflect light, even if it is borrowed light, for that too is divine.

May we merit to rise and shine again, until the time of Mashiach, when the moon and the sun will once again shine with equal strength, and the light of every Jew will be seen in its full glory.

Shabbat Shalom.